

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Book Intros)

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

1 Timothy

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During the final stage of Paul's ministry as an apostle, a serious problem arose in the church at Ephesus. Some of its leaders had become false teachers. Paul had warned that this would happen (Acts 20:29–31).

Now their influence was threatening the health and stability of the church. A capable leader was needed to restore order in God's household. Paul entrusted this task to Timothy, his trusted representative.

Setting

Paul first visited Ephesus during his second missionary journey (Acts 18:19–21). , but he did not stay long enough to do extensive ministry there. During his third missionary journey, he spent about three years in Ephesus (around AD 53–56, Acts 19). Later, while traveling to Jerusalem, Paul stopped at Miletus and met with the elders from Ephesus (Acts 20:17–38).

Paul then went to Jerusalem, where he was arrested. He was later transferred to Caesarea and then sent to Rome. There he lived under house arrest for about two years (AD 60–62, Acts 21–28). After his release, he resumed his missionary work. He may have traveled toward Spain (see Romans 15:24, 28), but it is also possible that his imprisonment led him to focus again on the eastern part of the Roman Empire. During this period, Paul continued to be involved with the church in Ephesus.

Timothy had worked closely with Paul during much of Paul's ministry in Ephesus (Acts 19:22). Now Paul had assigned him the task of addressing new problems in the church (1 Timothy 1:3). False teachers had appeared and seem to have been disrupting family and household life (1 Timothy 1:3; see 2:15; 3:4–5; 5:11–15; compare Titus 1:11). Paul wrote to Timothy to help him correct these harmful practices and prevent the false teachers from gaining further influence.

Summary

Paul first instructed Timothy to address the false teachers who claimed to be experts in the law (1 Timothy 1:3–20). Then Paul gives guidance about life in God's household, the church. He addresses prayer, the role of women in teaching, and church leadership (2:1–3:13). The false teachers had caused problems in each of these areas.

Paul then explains the purpose of his instructions and describes how Timothy should do them (3:14–4:16). After that, he returns to practical guidance for godly living. He focuses on relationships involving older and younger people, widows, elders, and masters (5:1–6:2). False teaching had also affected these relationships.

Finally, Paul returns to the subject of the false teachers themselves. This time, he focuses on their attitudes toward wealth and financial gain (6:2–21).

Author

There is a widely held view that the Pastoral Letters (1 Timothy, 2 Timothy, and Titus) were not written by Paul. According to this view, one of Paul's followers wrote these letters after Paul's death and used Paul's name when writing them.

There are several reasons, however, to believe that Paul was the author:

1. Until the 1800s, Christians consistently accepted these letters as Paul's. This included early church leaders whose native language was Greek and who were very familiar with Paul's other writings.
2. The early church would likely not have accepted these letters if there had been reason to believe they were falsely written in Paul's name.
3. The style of these letters differs in some ways from Paul's other letters. However, this difference may reflect the unique situations Paul was addressing and the particular stage of life and ministry in which he wrote them. It may also be explained by Paul's use of a different amanuensis (scribe, or professional writer) to help compose the letters.

For these reasons, it is reasonable to conclude that Paul wrote the Pastoral Letters.

Date of Writing

The Pastoral Letters (1 Timothy, 2 Timothy, and Titus) were most likely written after Paul's first imprisonment in Rome (AD 60 to 62, Acts 28:1–31) and before his death during Nero's persecution, probably around AD 64–65.

In 2 Timothy, Paul is imprisoned in Rome and expects to die soon (see 2 Timothy 4:6). This would seem to place the letters of 1 Timothy and Titus (written while Paul was still moving freely) in the time leading up to his arrest. How do these details fit with Acts?

One possibility is that Paul wrote 2 Timothy during his imprisonment in Rome, as described in Acts 28. If so, all three Pastoral Letters could fit within the timeline

recorded in Acts. According to this view, Paul was executed at the end of that imprisonment, around AD 62.

There are early Christian writings, however, that suggest Paul was released from this imprisonment (for example, 1 Clement 5:6–7, written around AD 95–97; see also Eusebius, Church History 2.22, written around AD 325). If so, Paul likely continued his missionary work and may have traveled to Spain. He was then probably arrested again and executed in Rome during Nero's persecution of Christians, around AD 64–65. According to this view, the letters to Timothy and Titus were written during this later period of Paul's ministry.

Several considerations support this view. First, there is no requirement that these letters fit within the events recorded in Acts. Second, the activities of Paul and his coworkers described in 1 Timothy and Titus do not match the details found in Acts. Likewise, the imprisonment described in 2 Timothy appears different from the imprisonment recorded in Acts 28. Finally, the distinctive style and content of these letters are easier to explain if they were written during a later period of Paul's ministry than his other letters.

The False Teachers

The false teachers described in 1 Timothy closely resemble those mentioned in 2 Timothy and Titus. Although it is difficult to identify their beliefs with certainty, the letters provide several clues. Their teaching included ascetic practices (strict self-denial, such as avoiding certain foods or marriage; see 1 Timothy 4:3; Titus 1:15) and had a strong Jewish emphasis (see 1 Timothy 1:7; Titus 1:10, 14; 3:9).

They claimed to have special knowledge (1 Timothy 6:20; Titus 1:16). They taught that the resurrection of believers had already happened (2 Timothy 2:18). They disrupted relationships within the church (2 Timothy 3:6–7; Titus 1:11). They may also have emphasized salvation through human effort rather than God's grace (2 Timothy 1:9; Titus 3:5).

Paul's strong response suggests that these teachers were spreading errors about Christ (see 1 Timothy 2:5–6; 3:16; 2 Timothy 2:8) and about the last days, or the period leading up to God's final judgment (see 1 Timothy 4:1–5; 2 Timothy 2:18; 3:1–9; Titus 2:11–14). They opposed Paul's message, encouraged ungodly behavior, and weakened the church's mission. For this reason, the churches needed qualified leaders who could teach the truth and correct error (see Titus 1:10–13; 2:6–8, 15).

Meaning and Message

First Timothy is a passionate and persuasive defense of the good news of Jesus Christ, its continuing spread throughout the world, and the new life it creates and encourages among believers (see 1 Timothy 3:14–16).

Paul's immediate concern was God's household, that is, the community of believers. In the society around them, people expected order within the family household. Family members had different roles, and people were expected to behave in ways that brought honor rather than shame. Paul believed that similar principles should guide life in God's household.

In many ways, God's household reflected accepted standards of proper behavior and the social structures of the time. At the same time, it differed from society where faithfulness to God required it. God's household lived by values and practices that were often very different from those of the surrounding culture.

God's people live in the world, but their lives are shaped by God's purposes rather than by the world's values. The world remains part of God's good creation (4:3–4; 6:17), yet it is temporary and is living through its final period of struggle against evil (4:1; 2 Timothy 3:1). As God's household lives in the present world, it also reflects the new creation that God is bringing about.

The mission of God's household is to spread the good news in the world and carry out God's purposes (see 1 Timothy 2:4–7). God's people should live in ways that support this mission (2:1–3:13; 5:1–6:2; see 1 Corinthians 9:19–23).

The false teachers, however, were promoting foolish ideas and harming the life of the church. For this reason, much of Paul's letter focuses on right conduct. The brief summaries of the good news in 1 Timothy (1 Timothy 1:15; 2:5–6; 3:16; 6:13–16) show what was truly at stake: a correct understanding of God's salvation in the present age. This message must be preserved, taught faithfully, and passed on to others. Its result should be a godly way of life.